Nancy LEISERING-HAYES

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Do you have a favorite teacher that made an impact on your life, and how? (Limit to 100 words)

Mr. Vandemerkt, my driver's ed teacher. We had so much fun! He taught me things like "If you see something in the road, DON'T aim for it!"

What was your favorite hang-out place in High School?

Library - it was a meeting place for my friends. We would grab poetry books off the shelf and read poems, like "In the Morning" by Paul Laurence Dunbar and just hang out.

What is your fondest memory of Willowbrook High School?(Limit to 100 words)

Stage crew for My Fair Lady and band.

Give us a brief history of your life since graduating: (Limit to 300 words)

Actually, I didn't graduate from Willowbrook because I was an AFS foreign exchange student to Thailand from March 1976 - March 1977. In the fall, I went to college in east TN. There I discovered backpacking and have enjoyed many backpacking trips since then. My first job was in New Orleans and it didn't pay much. I couldn't afford a car, so I bought a 10 speed bike. When I wasn't working, I was out on my bike exploring the Levy, Audubon Park, Lake Ponchatrain, etc.

After marrying Jeff Hayes(1983), our honeymoon was a of month driving, canoeing, backpacking and sometimes just camping for a month out west. Jeff bought a 10 speed bike and we took a bike trip from Decatur, GA to Birmingham, AL(where Jeff grew up) and down to Valdosta, GA camping along the way.

We have moved around a lot, first for Jeff's grad school education, then because he was a minister for different churches. We took youth groups on backpacking trips, led a backpacking camp in VA along the Appalachian Trail and eventually hiked the entire AT in sections over 3 years from GA to ME. We also hiked the Camino de Santiago from western France across Spain.

The last 26 years, we have lived in AL. For the last 10 years there we had a hiker hostel for backpackers on the Pinhoti Trail. It was fun to be Trail Angels, but it was a lot of work. Since our only grandson lived in Portland, we decided to move there and help as we can.